DOCUMENT-BASED QUESTION

1.2 Manifest Destiny

John O'Sullivan might have thought he was onto something when he coined the phrase "manifest destiny." However, he could not have predicted the impact that Americans' movement west would have on the nation's identity.

For the 19th-century Americans already considering moving westward, the idea of manifest destiny—that they had not only the right but also the responsibility to help expand the nation—was quite appealing. Settlers by the hundreds began crossing the Mississippi River and heading west.

John Gast's 1872 painting *American Progress* depicts the "spirit of America" as a goddess-like woman bathed in light and floating westward. She is leading **pioneers**, or people moving to a new and unfamiliar land, as they leave their settled lives and communities behind. The spirit carries a schoolbook, and she strings telegraph wire as she moves across the open land. Notice Gast's use of light and dark in this painting and how Native Americans and wildlife seem to react to the people headed their way.

CRITICAL VIEWING What do you notice about the direction the painting's subjects are facing? How does that reflect the concept of manifest destiny?



Autry Museum of the American West, Los Angeles

Gast painted *American Progress* just a few years after the end of the Civil War. In some ways, the painting's themes of modernization and new frontiers reflect a cultural desire to begin anew.

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DOCUMENT ONE

Primary Source: Essay
from "The Great Nation of Futurity,"
by John L. O'Sullivan, 1839

The concept of manifest destiny originated in John L. O'Sullivan's essay about what he perceived as the great future for the United States.

CONSTRUCTED RESPONSE On what authorities does O'Sullivan rest his ideas about the "onward march" of the United States?

> The expansive future is our arena. We are entering on its untrodden space, with the truths of God in our minds, beneficent objects in our hearts, and with a clear conscience unsullied by the past. We are the nation of human progress, and who will, what can, set limits to our onward march? Providence is with us, and no earthly power can. We point to the everlasting truth on the first page of our national declaration. In its magnificent domain of space and time, the nation of many nations is destined to manifest to mankind the excellence of divine principles.

DOCUMENT TWO

Primary Source: Artifact
Wheel from a covered wagon, wood and iron, c. 1830

The wheels on the covered wagons that carried the pioneers, like the wagon depicted in *American Progress* at left, were about four feet across. An iron band encircled the outside of the wheel, and iron strengthened the opening for the axle.

CONSTRUCTED RESPONSE What characteristics of the wheel can you see that make it suited to carrying a one-ton load more than 1,000 miles?



DOCUMENT THREE

Primary Source: Diary
from "The Letters and Journals of Narcissa Whitman,"
by Narcissa Whitman, 1836

Some of the first white settlers in the West were missionaries. Narcissa Whitman and her husband Marcus traveled to Oregon Country, hoping to spread Christianity among the Native Americans. Her diaries and letters home capture the experience of traveling the Oregon Trail and living in the Northwest. This excerpt is from July 27, 1836.

CONSTRUCTED RESPONSE How does Whitman describe the hardships of travel to the West?

> We are still in a dangerous country; but our company is large enough for safety. Our cattle endure the journey remarkably well. They supply us with sufficient milk for our tea and coffee, which is indeed a luxury. Do not think I regret coming. No, far from it; I would not go back for a world. I am contented and happy, notwithstanding I sometimes get very hungry and weary. Have six week's steady journey before us. Feel sometimes as if it were a long time to be traveling. Long for rest, but must not murmur. Feel to pity the poor Indian women, who are continually traveling in this manner during their lives, and know no other comfort.

SYNTHESIZE & WRITE

1. **REVIEW** Review what you have learned about the cultural, geographic, and political context in which the idea of manifest destiny emerged.
2. **RECALL** On your own paper, write the main ideas about manifest destiny inspired by Gast's painting, the writings of O'Sullivan and Whitman, and the wagon wheel.
3. **CONSTRUCT** Construct a topic sentence that answers this question: In what ways did Americans incorporate the idea of manifest destiny into their decisions about moving west?
4. **WRITE** Using evidence from this chapter and the documents and artifact, write an informative paragraph that supports your topic sentence in Step 3.

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